

***brown
& gold
& blood***

***an exploration of south asian womanhood
by pari marwah***

introduction

Staying up past bedtime in my older sister's room and begging to read her copy of Seventeen, thumbing through every issue of Femina I could find at the library, poring over pictures of Nick Jonas in the latest issue of Tiger beat, women's magazines have always sparked joy in me perhaps because they made me feel like I was in a secret club with my sister, my friends at school and my cool aunt. Women's magazines, especially teen magazines are often deemed silly and are laughed at for not focusing on more 'serious' issues. However, having a space that is aimed only at women, even if the content doesn't explicitly seek to ignite change, is revolutionary in itself.

Since the late 18th century, women have turned to magazines for a sense of comfort. The Ladies Magazine started in 1749 in Britain is said to be the first women's magazine to be significantly successful. For sixpence a copy, women could read about fashion, music, look at new sewing patterns as well as read excerpts of upcoming books. Though its content attempted to stay away from politics, it included articles from doctors concerning women's health issues including topics like breastfeeding.





Following the lead of these magazines in the west, Kamala Sathianadhan started the Indian Ladies Magazine in 1901, the first magazine to have an Indian woman as the editor. Though the magazine largely aligned itself with traditional Victorian ideals for women, it also touched on the changing role of women in India. Sathianadhan stuck to the aim of her magazine, which was to create a space for discussions focused on Indian women by carefully selecting articles from Indian writers that weren't too political but still served this purpose. By focusing on the Indian woman's domestic role, she ignited several conversations about their larger social and political role in the country. Though Indian Ladies Magazine had a huge British influence as was seen in the 'Homage to Queen Victoria' included in its maiden issue, still, by having a focus on Indian women it gave a voice to a group that never had one. Centring Indian women as its targeted audience was revolutionary itself.

The Barking Deer, Mumbai

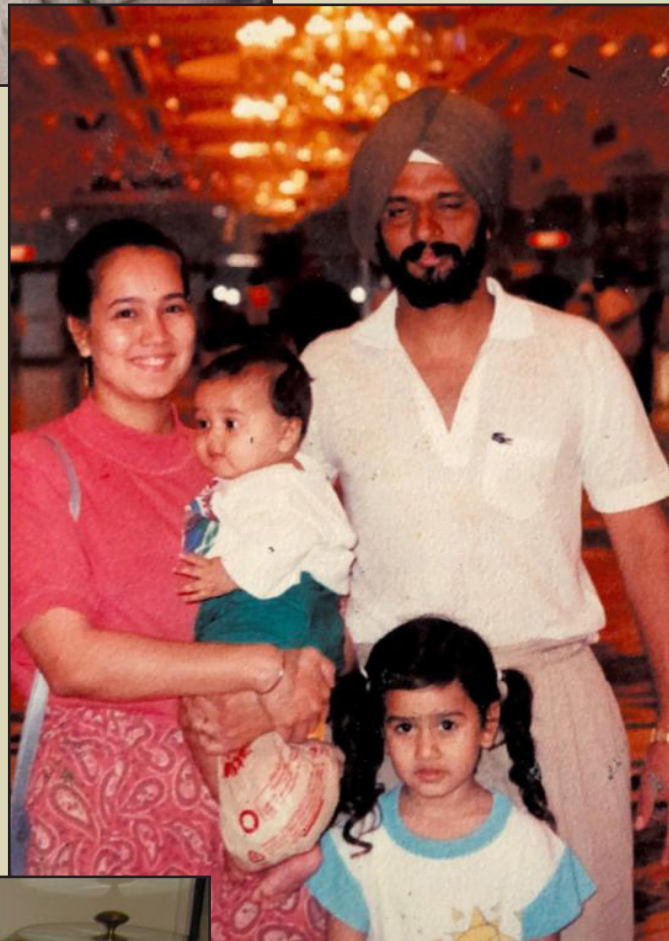


As I made my way through my teenage years, I started feeling a disconnect between myself and Western magazines. I wanted more and wanted to see myself in what I read. I wanted to hear about women who looked like me and had to grow up quicker than the girls I read about in Teen Vogue. Coincidentally, I made a new friend when I transferred to a new high school my senior year who introduced me to the concept of open mics. I didn't know such a concept existed and I certainly did not think it would exist in Mumbai. I decided to go to support her when she said she was reading at one soon, even though I wasn't exactly sure what to expect. I met her outside an unassuming bar tucked in quaint South Bombay by-lane. We walked inside and I looked around nervously as I thought to myself, we're 17, what were we doing at a bar? As we entered, the bartender loudly said, "ID?" as he dried a beer glass. Just as my face started to turn red and I contemplated leaving my friend there, she simply smiled at him and said, "We're here for the open mic!"

I followed her all the way past the tables, through a dingy hallway and up a spiral staircase that felt like it was a lawsuit waiting to happen. As I took my last step up the staircase, I was greeted by warm yellow light cast by string lights all over the ceiling. I found myself in a small cave-like attic that was packed with a crowd of mostly women. A woman with pink hair beckoned my friend towards her and scooped in to make space for us on one of the benches that lined the room. As I sat there, nervously introducing myself to the coolest girl I'd ever met, I didn't know that what followed next would have a profound effect on me. The pink haired girl rose from the bench and made her way up to the mic. As she started to speak, her voice filled the small room and everyone grew silent and turned to look at her as if she'd casted a spell. She talked about things I'd always felt but could never articulate even in my head. I heard the sound of snapping fingers as I felt myself tear up watching her say things I thought we weren't supposed to say, into a mic no less. This attic became my magic treehouse- as I walked up the stairs I'd find myself part of a completely different world. I felt warm and safe amongst those string lights, snapping fingers and voices that sounded like they were coming from within me.

Through this zine I'm aiming to recreate the warmth and safety of this attic. Zines are self-published, mostly made using inexpensive materials and have limited copies. They became the center of the riot grrrl movement pioneered by punk bands like Bratmobile and Bikini Kill, which were known for inviting women to come to the front of the crowd and sing along to their powerful lyrics. This ignited a fire in their fanbase made up of girls who had seen the ugly side of the punk scene. They started making their own zines discussing issues like sexual assault, sexuality, consent and sexism. Zines allowed girls to come together and collaborate on creating something that they had full agency over. The pamphlets were distributed among friends and at shows all over as girls danced to Rebel Girl. These shows I imagine felt like my secret attic; spaces where you could not only feel safe but also powerful.

As you go through this zine, I hope you see yourself in it's pages. I hope you feel the warmth from the string lights and hear the snap, snap, snap.



Interview with Balbir Marwah (59)

also known as Tai, my aunt and Beena.

Ages 8-10

I started assuming responsibility for my younger sister’s care. I was in charge of prep work to help my mother cook every meal. Slowly, I learned to cook too. I remember, one day I was frying puris in hot oil and didn’t know how to flip them and so I ended up burning three of my fingers.

She pauses for a minute to laugh.

I mean, it didn’t occur to me that I wasn’t supposed to know that as a 10-year-old. I just remember thinking, oh my god, that was such a stupid mistake!

Age 13

I remember being really excited about a debate competition I wanted to participate in at school. The morning of the competition, I woke up and found blood on my underwear. I knew it was a ‘thing’ that happened when you turned 13. I thought nothing of it, put on a cloth over my underwear, and went to school. By the way, menstrual pads weren’t even a thing back then in the 70s. I was so excited when it was my turn, I stood right up and confidently made my argument.

A classmate sitting next to me noticed the skirt of my school uniform had a huge red blood stain on it. She went up to our class teacher and informed her. I was taken to the principal’s office, and given a replacement uniform- well, they gave me a different skirt so it looked kind of off. I was told to go home which left me confused, why did I have to go home? I declined, went back, and finished the debate competition. My classmates asked me why I was wearing a different skirt and I told them about the stain. They nodded like they understood completely, but none of us really knew what the red stain meant.

Ages 15-18

When I got to age 15, I had three sisters already. I never really questioned why my mother would get pregnant every couple of years... I would just go, oh another sister to play with. I started to wonder why, and I realized it was because my father wanted a boy so badly. His parents died during the partition, so when he came to India he had no one. He would be shuffled around from relative to relative and so he wanted a son to carry forward his name, someone to stay and take care of him after his daughters got married.

I started tutoring this 4th grader when I was in the 7th grade. I would walk over to her house from mine every day, tutor her for an hour, and come back. I was paid 70 rupees a month (which is less than \$1 today). It wasn’t a lot, but it helped. I always worked knowing that the money I made was for my family. For my sisters.

I remember when I was 18, my uncle took all of us kids on a road trip to Bangalore. When I came back, I noticed my mother’s bulging stomach- she was pregnant again. I found myself hoping it was a boy this time, so it could finally end. Their prayers came true, it was a boy. I’d always assumed the role of a caregiver with all my siblings so I never really felt ‘equal’ to them. But especially with my brother, to date I can’t really see him as my sibling, he is still like a son to me. I would change his diapers and take him to the park as a 19-year-old. People would ask me, don’t you feel weird? I never really understood why I was supposed to feel weird.

Age 19

I studied commerce in college, well accounts to be exact. I switched in my senior year though, I just couldn’t handle all the numbers. I’d heard management didn’t involve numbers from my neighbor who studied it and so I switched.

(She laughs) To be honest, I was desperate. They wouldn’t even let us use a calculator in the examinations!

I didn’t have money for tutors or any kind of extra resources. Even as a child, I studied for the local language examinations by asking the woman who I used to buy milk from to teach me. I’ve always found a way! I would go to the library and track down all these books from foreign authors. Back then there weren’t any popular textbooks, not ones that helped anyway. So, I would research extensively to make my own textbook. My classmates always asked for my notes and I would readily agree. I never cared much for competition, I’ve always wanted to help.

At the same time, I got a job tutoring at a private tuition company. It was hard work, going to class in the mornings and afternoons and then going to the tutoring center in the evenings. My younger sister, who was 16 at the time, was a kindergarten teacher already. I felt motivated knowing that if my younger sister could facilitate parent-teacher conferences, I could do this too.

I graduated at the top of my class. My professors told me about a teaching job that was vacant at a college some 10 kilometers away. I’d never traveled this far, and he’d warned me that five professors had quit this job in the last 5 months due to the rowdy nature of the students. Not to mention, the ‘kids’ I was supposed to be teaching were 17, and I had just turned 21. I showed up on my first day to find that another teacher was teaching my class already. I stood at the doorway.

Excuse me? I have a lecture here.

He said I was late and should go take a seat.

I cleared my throat and said, “Actually, I mean to say I’m taking a lecture here.”

(She laughs heartily) I’ll never forget the look on his face as he collected his belongings and scurried out of the classroom. I went up to the podium, wrote down the subject of my class on the blackboard, and started teaching. I didn’t say hi or introduce myself but the students loved me, because I had the best notes!

Ages 20-21

My parents told me we were going to buy a TV and so they wanted me to go along with them. Midway through the ride, they told me we were actually going to see a prospective match for me. I’d been recommended to his family after their relative saw me helping out at the Gurudwara. He was impressed with my active participation at the temple as well as my good grades.

I was wearing my hair in two braids and wore a simple salwar kameez when I met my husband for the first time.. We didn’t really get to talk. I remember the only question he asked me was, “What are your teaching hours like?” And that was it. Our families started celebrating when they suddenly stopped and realized they’d forgotten to ask me if I agreed to the marriage. I thought to myself, I don’t really know anything about marriage, or boys. My parents must’ve thought about this and so I should trust them. I said yes and just like that, I was engaged.

On my wedding day, there were whispers floating around. “Did you hear? Her parents didn’t give a dowry” I didn’t know I was supposed to have a dowry or a trousseau. My father-in-law shut down all this gossip by saying that he only wanted me for his son, not my belongings. I’d always had your grandfather in my corner. He was like a protective wall between me and the world. He told me not to worry about getting my clothes stitched or having jewelry made and said that he would take care of it. He encouraged me to pursue my master’s degree, and when my daughter was born he stood proud and said he would treat her like he would a grandson, and that she would get the best education he could afford, even when people would make snarky remarks to him about having several granddaughters already.

(Tai means aunt, Tayaji means uncle)

Life got easier after that. We moved to a new, bigger place. Tayaji and I had our own bedroom and welcomed your brother. Your father got you finally after going through a really hard time. He was overjoyed and loved you more than anything else the moment you were born. You know how things were when you were growing up...your mother, she was slowly killing you. You would cling to me at all times, that’s why I started calling you ‘lamb’ after Mary and The Little Lamb. I knew I had to be your mom, not your aunt. I couldn’t leave you with your mother no matter what the others said. They said I shouldn’t come between a mother and her daughter, and it was hard for me to hear this every time, my own mother said this to me too, did you know? I didn’t like being framed as a villain, but I had to protect you from your mother if you can even call her that. If... If I just left you alone, you wouldn’t have survived. And so, I became your mom. Through it all, I always have been. You’ve always been my daughter. Your Tayaji, your dad, and I love you a little too much in the hopes that you never feel like it’s not enough.

Johnsons Baby Oil



I am because of my aunt. I am because of the mornings spent in front of the TV, pokemon theme song blaring in Hindi as my aunt’s fingers dexterously weaved strands of my hair into tightly knit braids looping under over under over

Every morning was like this her fingers working feverishly pausing ever so often to squeeze the Johnson’s baby oil bottle onto her fingers my eyes barely opening her glancing at the clock on the wall saying you’re late again we have to hurry me running out the door Me running past the nuns trying to make it up the steps before the final bell

Tai I made it

I made it, Tai

You can rest now you can wash the Johnson’s baby oil off your hands you can go down to the pool for an extra hour you can go to sleep early you can watch your show for 30 more minutes you can rest you can rest

If They Should Come For Us
Fatimah Asghar

Fatimah’s poetry draws heavily on her family’s experiences during the partition, and how they affect her today as a queer, Muslim person.

these are my people & I find
them on the street & shadow
through any wild all wild
my people my people
a dance of strangers in my blood
the old woman’s sari dissolving to wind
bindi a new moon on her forehead
I claim her my kin & sew
the star of her to my breast
the toddler dangling from stroller
hair a fountain of dandelion seed
at the bakery I claim them too
the sikh uncle at the airport
who apologizes for the pat
down the muslim man who abandons
his car at the traffic light drops
to his knees at the call of the azan
& the muslim man who sips
good whiskey at the start of maghrib
the lone khala at the park
pairing her kurta with crocs
my people my people I can’t be lost
when I see you my compass
is brown & gold & blood
my compass a muslim teenager
snapback & high-tops gracing
the subway platform
mashallah I claim them all
my country is made
in my people’s image
if they come for you they
come for me too in the dead
of winter a flock of
aunties step out on the sand
their dupattas turn to ocean
a colony of uncles grind their palms
& a thousand jasmines bell the air
my people I follow you like constellations
we hear the glass smashing the street
& the nights opening their dark
our names this country’s wood
for the fire my people my people
the long years we’ve survived the long
years yet to come I see you map
my sky the light your lantern long
ahead & I follow I follow

a dance of strangers in my blood
the old woman’s sari dissolving to wind
bindi a new moon on her forehead
I claim her my kin & sew
the star of her to my breast

the sikh uncle at the airport
who apologizes for the pat
down the muslim man who abandons
his car at the traffic light drops
to his knees at the call of the azan

my people my people I can’t be lost
when I see you my compass
is brown & gold & blood
my compass a muslim teenager
snapback & high-tops gracing
the subway platform
mashallah I claim them all
my country is made
in my people’s image

a colony of uncles grind their palms

our names this country’s wood
for the fire my people my people

Fatimah echoes the inexplicable feeling that washes over me whenever i see ‘my people’ too. I especially love the line, “I claim her my kin & sew the star of her to my breast’. The words ‘sew’ and ‘to my breast’ capture perfectly how deeply I feel when i see my people, almost an ache in my heart. They capture the pain I feel in my body and my blood.

No matter how different, our people are our people. When I see a sikh man driving a taxi, I see my my grandfather who drove taxis to support his family after Partition. When I see a young, sprightly brown teenage girl at the k-pop store, giggling away with her friends as they sift through the CDs of their favorite boy bands, I see my cousin sister who grew up in New Jersey and supported her Indian immigrant mom through an abusive marriage, but never missed a k-pop concert. I see my people everywhere, know that I come from them, and them from me. Fatimah talks about the protective feeling we share over our people. Whenever I see a brown family lost at the subway station, or around the city- my heart reaches out to tell them they need to take the 6 because it goes local instead of the 4 or 5.

The word ‘colony’ here rings deep for me, not only does it reference our homeland’s status before Partition, but manages to perfectly describe what our current presence in the West feels like.

Fatimah isn’t afraid to make people uncomfortable, as she calls out how our names are used as fuel for the countries’ fire of hate. Fatimah is Muslim and as we know, as soon as a Muslim names rolls off one’s tongue, you brace yourself automatically for what is to follow. You wait for the air to change, to be called aside for ‘random selection’ at TSA. Though my father and my family is spared from our names being used against us, my father’s turban, his pagdi is instead used as kindling for their fire.

the long years we’ve survived the long
years yet to come I see you map
my sky the light your lantern long
ahead & I follow I follow

The women before me continued to survive and so now I understand, that every day I continue to survive is not only a victory for me but for the girls who will come after me. I do it for my grandmother, who struggled with believing she wasn’t a good mother and couldn’t do much because of her schizophrenia. I do it inspite of my struggles, in spite of all the odds stacked up against me, in the hopes that maybe the universe will send her a message- I’m in America, getting my degree and I’m happy, in spite of my mental illness.

Like Fatimah, I hold the experiences, the trauma the women who came before me, the women who exist with me, the women who will come after me within me. I hold them all within me, like it or not they’re simply a part of me. I think for the longest time I’ve tried to separate myself from it, but it would mean ripping my heart out of my chest. This project is a way for me to reach inside my heart and to hold it tenderly. It’s a way for me to tell my aunt how much she means to me, how much I love her, how I can see all that she’s done for me finally. But most importantly, I can see her, without the label mother, sister, wife attached to her.

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